

Problems of State Building and Nation Building in Pakistan

Conceptual Framework: State Building

- • Creation of effective governing institutions
- • Establishing law and order
- • Taxation and administration
- • Service delivery and development
- • Monopoly over legitimate use of force

Conceptual Framework: Nation Building

- • Creating shared identity and loyalty
- • Integrating ethnic and linguistic groups
- • Developing national symbols and ideology
- • Promoting political participation
- • Building emotional attachment to the state

Historical Context at Independence

- • Geographically divided country
- • Few administrative offices inherited
- • Economic weakness and lack of industry
- • Refugee influx of millions
- • Immediate survival challenges dominated policy

Overview of Core Problems

- • Administrative weaknesses
- • Political instability
- • Leadership crisis
- • Federal disputes
- • Provincial autonomy demands
- • Regional inequalities
- • Military dominance

Administrative Problems: Shortage of Personnel

- • Most experienced Hindu officials migrated to India
- • Severe shortage of trained bureaucrats
- • Ministries lacked expertise
- • Slow decision making
- • Dependence on a small civil service elite

Administrative Problems: Refugee Rehabilitation

- • 7–8 million refugees resettled
- • Housing, jobs, food shortages
- • Social tensions in urban centers
- • Budget diverted from development
- • Long-term strain on governance

Administrative Problems: Weak Institutions

- • New departments created hastily
- • Lack of coordination
- • Poor policy planning
- • Emergency management mindset
- • Institutional instability became normal

Centralization of Administration

- • Decision-making concentrated in Karachi/Islamabad
- • Limited local government
- • Provinces dependent on center
- • Slow service delivery
- • Public alienation increased

Political Problems: Weak Political Parties

- • Muslim League was a movement, not structured party
- • Lack of internal democracy
- • Factionalism and personal rivalries
- • No strong opposition parties
- • Poor political training

Political Problems: Leadership Crisis

- • Death of Jinnah (1948)
- • Assassination of Liaquat Ali Khan (1951)
- • No consensus national leader
- • Power struggles among elites
- • Weak strategic direction

Frequent Government Changes

- • Rapid replacement of prime ministers
- • Cabinet instability
- • Policy inconsistency
- • Loss of public confidence
- • Failure to consolidate democracy

Executive Interference in Politics

- • Governor Generals dismissed governments
- • Dissolution of Constituent Assembly (1954)
- • Undermined parliamentary supremacy
- • Strengthened authoritarian tendencies
- • Constitutional norms weakened

Civil–Military Alliance

- • Politicians weak and divided
- • Bureaucracy and military more organized
- • Security concerns prioritized
- • Military influence expanded
- • Foundation for future coups

Nation Building Problems: Ethnic Diversity

- • Punjabis, Bengalis, Sindhis, Pashtuns, Baloch, Mohajirs
- • Distinct languages and cultures
- • Regional histories and loyalties
- • Difficult to create uniform identity
- • Cultural recognition became political issue

Language Controversy

- • Urdu declared national language
- • Bengali majority opposed decision
- • 1952 Language Movement
- • Student protests and casualties
- • Strengthened Bengali nationalism

Ideological Challenges

- • Islamic state vs democratic state debate
- • Role of religion in lawmaking
- • Minority rights concerns
- • No clear consensus
- • Ideological ambiguity persisted

Economic Inequalities

- • Development focused in West Pakistan
- • Industrial concentration in few cities
- • East Pakistan produced foreign exchange
- • Unequal resource allocation
- • Perception of exploitation grew

Security and Defense Priorities

- • Wars with India (1948, 1965)
- • Large defense budgets
- • Reduced spending on education and health
- • Military prestige increased
- • Social development neglected

Constitutional Problems: Nature of Federation

- • Debate over centralized vs federal state
- • East Pakistan demanded representation by population
- • West Pakistan feared domination
- • Constitutional deadlock emerged
- • Delayed constitution making

Representation Crisis

- • East Pakistan had majority population
- • West held more administrative power
- • Demand for majority rule
- • Parity formula controversies
- • Political mistrust deepened

One Unit Scheme 1955

- • West Pakistan merged into one province
- • Designed to balance East numerically
- • Eliminated smaller provincial identities
- • Seen as artificial arrangement
- • Increased resentment

Impact of One Unit

- • Sindhi, Pashtun, and Baloch opposition
- • Loss of cultural autonomy
- • Centralization of resources
- • Reduced local participation
- • Failure to promote unity

Provincial Autonomy Demands

- • Control over taxation and revenue
- • Authority over education and culture
- • Greater legislative powers
- • Fair share in development funds
- • Persistent political conflict

Fiscal Centralization

- • Center controlled major taxes
- • Provinces dependent on grants
- • Limited financial independence
- • Weak service delivery
- • Increased complaints of neglect

Federal Instability and National Integration

- • Disputes weakened trust in federation
- • Provinces felt marginalized
- • Rise of regional movements
- • Declining national cohesion
- • Threat to unity of state

Consequences for Nation Building

- • Weak shared identity
- • Growth of regional nationalism
- • Political alienation in East Pakistan
- • Mass protests by late 1960s
- • Foundations of later disintegration

Key Lessons and Insights

- • Strong institutions must be participatory
- • Federalism should protect provincial rights
- • Political parties require organization
- • Equitable development promotes unity
- • Democracy essential for nation building